

DESIGNING WITH PLANTS

There is a plant for every situation, be it a tree, shrub, perennial, annual, or bulb. When designing with plants, you can include examples from all the plant groups to ensure year-round interest, or focus on just

one or two groups for a contemporary look. The key to success is to vary shapes, textures, and colors, and consider how each plant will work with others in your border and in the garden as a whole.

Defining plant groups

Different plant groups fulfill different functions in a design, and understanding how each can be used to the best effect will help you to create a balanced, coordinated display. Trees, large shrubs, and some climbers provide the framework for a planting scheme, offering permanent structure, height, and depth, as well as color and texture. Midrange plants include smaller shrubs, herbaceous perennials, some bulbs, and grasses. They help to define the style of your garden, and provide seasonal interest with their flowers and foliage. Focal plants offer eye-catching accents, drawing the eye to a border or vista, while groundcover plants create a low mat of leaves and blooms at a lower level. Annuals and biennials will put on a show from spring to early fall in containers, and fill the gaps between more permanent planting groups in borders.

Structural plants

Permanent structural plants, such as trees, shrubs, and hedges, make a vital contribution to the shape and form of the garden, and identifying these key plants, and deciding where to position them, is the first step in producing a coherent design.

Evergreens provide year-round interest, while deciduous trees and shrubs inject



dramatic displays of flowers in spring and colorful foliage in fall. Hedges not only define boundaries, they also offer shelter and create privacy. Evergreen hedges provide colorful year-round screens and backdrops for other planting groups, while deciduous hedges allow in more light and offer seasonal color. Either type can be formal or informal in style, with leaf size, color, and flowers to consider. Leafy shrubs work in a similar way to hedges, providing

ABOVE Creating structural features with plants

The combination of box hedges and conical yew topiary creates a dramatic structural and textural contrast to the less formal perennial flower borders.

a green foliage backdrop to smaller midrange plants and groundcover.

You can also use structural plants to frame or block out views, and to lead the eye around the garden. In addition, trees and shrubs can help to create a visual link between the garden and the landscape beyond, extending the display. Repeated plants will also help to make connections between different areas of the garden and different planting areas.

Structural plants come in many different forms and shapes; for example, they may be rounded and neat, such as choisyas and photinias; spiky and textural, like mahonias, hollies, and yuccas; or looser in form, such as laburnums, weeping pears, or garryas. Many plants can be manipulated to create artificial structural effects, such as climbers clambering over arches, arbors, and pergolas, or along walls. Others can be clipped into topiary shapes; boxwood, yew, and holly are all good candidates for topiary balls, pyramids, and spirals.

LEFT Using focal plants

In this beautiful country garden, naturalized tulips in vibrant shades create a carpet of spring color. The focal plant in this design is *Malus floribunda*, with its light-reflecting white blossom and architectural shape.

